# NCCLPol: Verified, Composable Policy Execution for GPU Collective Communication

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## ABSTRACT

NCCL's plugin system allows operators to customize collective communication behavior, but plugins execute as native code with no isolation, verification, or structured state sharing. We present NCCLPol, which embeds a userspace eBPF runtime inside NCCL's plugin interface to provide load-time verification, typed eBPF maps for cross-plugin state sharing, and atomic policy hot-reload. NCCLPol requires zero NCCL modifications. Our evaluation shows 52–100 ns of CPU overhead per policy decision (<0.06% of collective latency), 14/14 correct verifier verdicts across seven safe and seven unsafe programs, and sub-microsecond atomic policy swaps with zero call loss.

## 1 INTRODUCTION

Large-scale GPU training depends on collective communication performance. The choice of algorithm (ring vs. tree), protocol (LL vs. Simple), and channel count can shift collective latency by orders of magnitude [1, 2, 4]. NVIDIA's NCCL [4] exposes a plugin system—tuner, profiler, net, and env plugins—that allows operators to customize these decisions. This extensibility has enabled custom tuning at major cloud providers [1].

However, every NCCL plugin executes as native code in NCCL's address space with no safety guarantees. A null-pointer dereference crashes the training job; an infinite loop hangs the communicator; an off-by-one error silently corrupts NCCL internal state. In production clusters where jobs run for days across thousands of GPUs, such failures waste enormous resources and are difficult to diagnose. Furthermore, NCCL provides no mechanism for cross-plugin communication—a profiler cannot pass latency measurements to a tuner—and no way to update a plugin without restarting the job.

We observe that eBPF's execution model is a natural fit for NCCL plugins. The key insight is that NCCL's policy hot path, `getCollInfo()`, executes on the CPU and is latency-tolerant: the collective it configures takes microseconds to milliseconds on the GPU, making 50–100 ns of CPU overhead negligible. eBPF's map abstraction directly addresses the cross-plugin state-sharing gap, and eBPF's atomic program replacement enables policy hot-reload.

NCCLPol embeds bpftime [8] inside a standard NCCL tuner plugin. Policy authors write restricted C compiled to BPF bytecode, verified at load time, and JIT-compiled to native code. The system operates within NCCL's stock plugin ABI, requiring zero modifications to NCCL itself. This paper makes four contributions:

(1) The case for verified extensibility in collective communication: eBPF resolves the safety–customizability tension with negligible overhead (§2).
(2) A map-based composability model enabling closed-loop profiler-to-tuner adaptation (§3).
(3) Atomic policy hot-reload with 0.774 µs swap time and zero call loss across 400,000 invocations (§3).
(4) Evaluation on NCCL 2.29.7 with RTX 5090 hardware showing 52–100 ns CPU overhead and end-to-end GPU overhead within measurement noise (§5).

## 2 BACKGROUND AND MOTIVATION

*NCCL plugin architecture.* NCCL organizes extensibility around four plugin types loaded via `dlopen`: the *tuner* plugin's `getCollInfo` selects algorithm, protocol, and channel count per collective call; the *profiler* plugin receives timestamped event callbacks; the *net* plugin controls network connections; and the *env* plugin sets runtime parameters. These plugins are independent extension points with no cross-plugin communication mechanism and no verification of correctness.

*The safety gap.* Native plugins execute with full process privileges. A null dereference produces an immediate `SIGSEGV`, terminating the training job. An off-by-one error overwrites NCCL internal state, causing silent corruption. An infinite loop hangs the communicator indefinitely. In all cases, the root cause is that `dlopen`-based extensions have no safety net. The situation worsens when operators must roll out plugin updates across a fleet without a mechanism for safe hot-reload.

*Why eBPF fits.* Three properties make eBPF well-suited: (1) a generous overhead budget—`getCollInfo()` runs on the CPU before GPU-side collectives that take microseconds to milliseconds, so 50–100 ns of eBPF overhead is negligible; (2) typed maps that provide concurrent, verified state sharing between profiler and tuner without ad-hoc shared memory; and (3) atomic program replacement for hot-reload with verification of the replacement before swap.

## 3 DESIGN

### 3.1 Design Tensions

*T1: Safety vs. overhead.* Verification at every invocation would add milliseconds; verification only at load time (1–5 ms, amortized over the job lifetime) trades per-call checks for a one-time cost. This relies on the invariant that verified BPF bytecode, once JIT-compiled, cannot violate its safety guarantees at runtime. The tradeoff: verification catches memory safety and termination bugs, not semantic correctness.

*T2: Structured sharing vs. flexibility.* All cross-component state sharing uses typed eBPF maps with atomic access semantics. Maps constrain policies to fixed-size keys/values, but NCCL policy state

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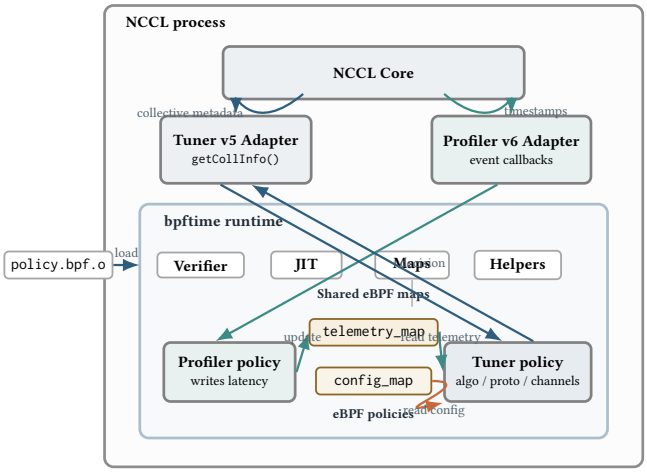


**Figure 1: NCCLPol architecture. Policy programs are verified via PREVAIL, JIT-compiled by bpftime, and execute inside the NCCL process. Profiler and tuner communicate through shared typed eBPF maps. The entire system loads as standard NCCL plugins.**

is inherently simple (per-communicator scalars), and structured sharing eliminates the locking bugs that plague ad-hoc native plugin state sharing.

*T3: Availability vs. consistency during updates.* Hot-reload atomically swaps the function pointer; any in-progress call completes under the old policy, the next call uses the new one. No call is lost. If the new policy fails verification, the old policy continues. The tradeoff: different threads may briefly execute different policies, which is acceptable because collective decisions are independent per call.

*T4: Compatibility vs. capability.* NCCLPol operates within NCCL's existing plugin ABI—no source modifications, no custom builds, no kernel modules. The action space is limited to algorithm, protocol, and channel count selection. Deeper interventions are outside scope, but the exposed knobs cover the most impactful tuning decisions.

## 3.2 Threat Model

Policies are written by platform operators, not untrusted tenants. The eBPF verifier (PREVAIL-based) checks memory safety, bounded execution, stack safety, and helper whitelisting. The system does *not* protect against resource exhaustion, side channels, bugs in the trusted computing base (bpftime JIT, PREVAIL verifier, host plugin), or semantically incorrect decisions. This provides defense in depth—eliminating crashes, hangs, and memory corruption—analogous to the Linux kernel's eBPF model.

## 3.3 Architecture

Figure 1 shows the architecture. Policy authors write restricted C compiled to BPF ELF objects. At load time, each program is verified (abstract interpretation over all execution paths) and JIT-compiled to x86-64 code. The map subsystem provides intra-policy state and cross-plugin communication: a profiler eBPF program writes latency observations; the tuner reads them. Hot-reload verifies and JIT-compiles a replacement, then atomically swaps the function pointer via compare-and-swap.

*Policy programming model.* A policy takes a `policy_context` (collective type, message size, rank count) and writes algorithm, protocol, and channel count decisions. The verifier ensures policies only read input fields and write output fields. Map lookups require null checks before dereference—the same check that prevents the most common native plugin crash (null-pointer dereference after failed lookup).

**Listing 1: Size-aware tuning policy (12 lines of logic).**

```
SEC("policy")
int size_aware(struct policy_context *ctx) {
  if (ctx->msg_size <= 4096) {
    ctx->algorithm = NCCL_ALGO_TREE;
    ctx->protocol = NCCL_PROTO_SIMPLE;
  } else if (ctx->msg_size <= 65536) {
    ctx->algorithm = NCCL_ALGO_TREE;
    ctx->protocol = NCCL_PROTO_LL;
  } else {
    ctx->algorithm = NCCL_ALGO_RING;
    ctx->protocol = NCCL_PROTO_LL;
  }
  return 0;
}
```

More complex policies read profiler-provided latency from eBPF maps and adapt channel count dynamically. The adaptive channels policy performs a map lookup per call, checks the result for null, and adjusts channels based on observed latency. This closed-loop control has no built-in support in NCCL's native plugin architecture, where tuner and profiler plugins share no state mechanism.

# 4 IMPLEMENTATION

NCCLPol is implemented in approximately 2,500 lines of C/C++ (plugin host) and 500 lines of restricted C (policy programs).

*NCCL integration challenges.* NCCL's tuner API uses cost arrays rather than direct algorithm IDs: the tuner sets costs to zero for preferred choices and to a sentinel value for others. Our integration translates eBPF policy outputs into cost array entries. NCCL also passes a maximum channel count that the tuner must respect; our native baseline layer clamps the policy's request. Communicator identification required deriving a stable ID from the context pointer via hashing.

*Hot-reload mechanism.* The active policy is stored as an atomic function pointer. Reload has three phases: (1) verify the new BPF program, (2) JIT-compile it, (3) atomic compare-and-swap on the pointer. The total reload cost is ~7.3 ms; only the final swap (0.774 µs) touches the hot path. The old pointer is retained until in-flight calls drain. If the replacement fails verification, the swap is aborted and the old policy continues—the system never enters an unverified state.

# 5 EVALUATION

We evaluate three research questions: (RQ1) CPU overhead and decomposition, (RQ2) verifier effectiveness and hot-reload integrity, and (RQ3) policy expressiveness within the eBPF model.

**Table 1: CPU microbenchmark (1M calls each). eBPF policies add 52–100 ns over native code.**

| Policy | P50 (ns) | P99 (ns) | ΔP50 |
|---|---|---|---|
| Native baseline | 10 | 16 | — |
| `noop` | 61 | 74 | +51 |
| `size_aware_v2` | 62 | 73 | +52 |
| `lookup_only` | 88 | 104 | +78 |
| `lookup_update` | 113 | 134 | +103 |
| `adaptive_channels` | 112 | 136 | +102 |
| `slo_enforcer` | 110 | 134 | +100 |

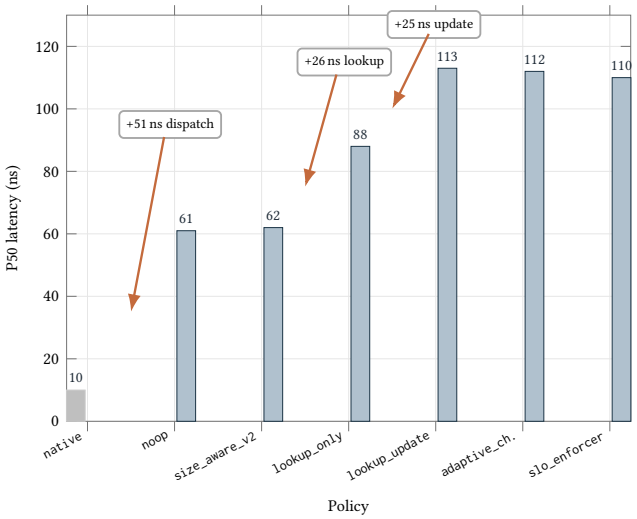


**Figure 2: Overhead decomposition. The base dispatch cost (+51 ns) dominates; each map lookup adds ∼26 ns and each map update adds ∼25 ns.**

*Testbed.* CPU microbenchmarks run on a 24-core x86-64 platform with isolated cores; each benchmark performs 1 million calls and reports P50/P99 latencies. GPU experiments use a single NVIDIA RTX 5090 with CUDA 12.9 and NCCL 2.29.7, emulating 2 ranks over socket transport. While modest in scale, this exercises the full plugin integration path. The CPU-side policy overhead is independent of rank count.

## 5.1 RQ1: CPU Overhead

Table 1 reports per-call latency. Figure 2 shows the overhead staircase: the `noop` policy isolates the dispatch cost (+51 ns, including context setup and function pointer indirection); each map lookup adds ∼26 ns (hash computation + table lookup); each map update adds ∼25 ns (key hashing + value copy). The overhead is predictable: approximately $51 + 26n_{\text{lookup}} + 25n_{\text{update}}$ ns.

P99 latencies track P50 within 20–25 ns, indicating minimal variance from JIT-compiled code with no allocation or system calls.

**Table 2: End-to-end AllReduce latency on RTX 5090, 2 ranks over socket transport. eBPF overhead is within measurement noise.**

| Size | No Plugin (µs) | noop (µs) | size_aware (µs) |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 KB | 2.16 | 2.21 | 2.13 |
| 1 MB | 3.98 | 4.02 | 4.03 |
| 128 MB | 175.42 | 175.51 | 175.47 |

**Table 3: Verifier results: 14/14 correct verdicts. Each unsafe program targets a distinct bug class. These are author-constructed test cases.**

| Program | Bug Class | Result |
|---|---|---|
| *Safe policies (7)* | | |
| `noop`, `size_aware`, `size_aware_v2`, `lookup_only`, `lookup_update`, `adaptive_ch.`, `slo_enforcer` | — | ACCEPT |
| *Unsafe programs (7)* | | |
| `bad_lookup` | Null ptr deref | REJECT |
| `bad_oob_access` | OOB ctx read | REJECT |
| `bad_unregistered` | Illegal helper | REJECT |
| `bad_stack_overflow` | Stack overflow | REJECT |
| `bad_infinite_loop` | Unbounded loop | REJECT |
| `bad_write_ctx` | Write input field | REJECT |
| `bad_div_zero` | Division by zero | REJECT |

*Context.* The most complex policy adds 100 ns over native code. For a 128 MB AllReduce (175 µs on our GPU), this is 0.06% of collective latency. Even for 1 KB messages (∼2 µs), the overhead is under 5%.

*End-to-end GPU overhead.* Table 2 shows GPU-measured collective latency at three representative message sizes. The eBPF overhead is within measurement noise across all sizes. The CPU-side 52–100 ns is invisible because it occurs before the GPU collective launch, and NCCL's internal processing between `getCollInfo()` and kernel launch adds microseconds that dwarf the policy cost.

*Limitations.* These benchmarks use isolated cores on a single node with socket transport. Production deployments with NUMA effects and concurrent GPU DMA may show higher variance. The overhead formula is an empirical fit to our policies; policies with larger map values may deviate. We do not test multi-node or InfiniBand configurations.

## 5.2 RQ2: Safety and Hot-Reload

Table 3 shows verifier behavior on 14 programs. Each unsafe program targets a specific failure mode: the same null-dereference bug that crashes a native plugin with `SIGSEGV` is rejected at load time with an actionable error message ("must check != NULL before dereference"). The verifier tracks register types, pointer provenance, and value ranges to detect out-of-bounds access, unbounded loops, stack overflow, unauthorized helpers, input-field writes, and potential division by zero.

*Safety comparison.* We implemented `bad_lookup` as a native C plugin. Loading it into NCCL crashes the process immediately. The eBPF version is rejected before executing a single instruction. This is the core safety proposition: common bugs that crash training jobs with native plugins are caught at load time.

*Hot-reload integrity.* We continuously invoke `getCollInfo()` while swapping the active policy. The atomic swap completes in 0.774 µs; the full reload (verify + JIT + swap) takes ~7.3 ms. Across 400,000 invocations, we observe zero failed or lost calls. The reload is triggered at call 200,000; the first call under the new policy occurs at call 254,709 (the intervening ~54,700 calls complete under the old policy while verification and JIT run concurrently). When we attempt to hot-reload an unsafe policy, it is rejected and the current policy continues uninterrupted. This fail-safe property means operator mistakes during updates cannot crash a running job.

*Limitations.* The verifier test suite is author-constructed; we do not claim coverage of all possible unsafe patterns. A real-world evaluation would benefit from a corpus of actual plugin bugs. The hot-reload test uses a single process; we do not test across ranks or under real GPU load.

## 5.3 RQ3: Policy Expressiveness

We demonstrate four policy capabilities beyond simple algorithm selection. We frame this as an expressiveness demonstration: we show that the eBPF programming model can express these patterns, not that the resulting parameter changes improve end-to-end training outcomes. Outcome evaluation on production workloads is future work.

*Closed-loop adaptation.* With the profiler plugin writing real collective latency into a shared eBPF map, the `adaptive_channels` tuner adjusts channels from 8 to 10 over successive collectives on our GPU testbed. Without profiler feedback, the same policy remains static at 8 channels. This confirms that profiler data flows through the eBPF map and affects tuner decisions—a feedback loop with no built-in support in NCCL's native plugin architecture.

*Multi-tenant differentiation.* The `slo_enforcer` policy serves two communicators in the same process with different SLOs: communicator 1 (SLO $\leq$ 1 ms) receives TREE / LL / 8 channels; communicator 2 (SLO $\leq$ 10 ms) receives RING / Simple / 1 channel. Per-communicator state in eBPF maps keyed by `comm_id` provides logical state separation.

*Contention-aware adaptation.* Figure 3 shows the adaptive channels policy's response to three contention phases over 300,000 calls. During baseline (low latency), channels ramp to 12. Under injected contention (10× latency), channels drop to 2. Upon recovery, channels return to 12. This behavior emerges from the map-based feedback loop without special contention-detection logic. We note that contention was injected synthetically; stability under real contention patterns remains to be validated.

*Multi-collective coverage.* NCCLPol policies work across AllReduce, AllGather, ReduceScatter, and Broadcast. AllReduce selects TREE for small messages and RING for large ones; the other collectives default to RING. A single policy expresses collective-type-aware tuning strategies covering NCCL's full range of collective operations.

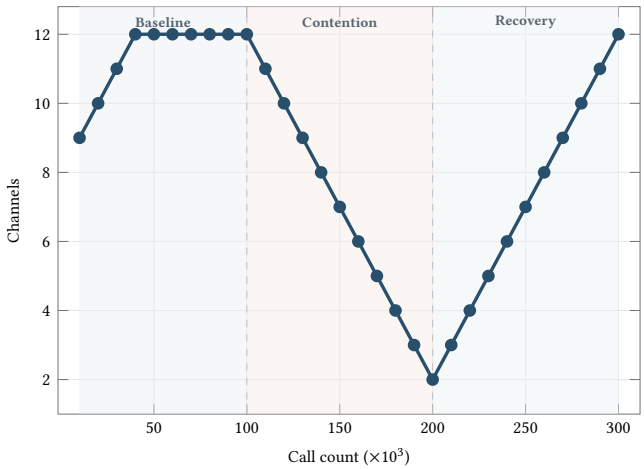


**Figure 3: Channel adaptation under changing contention. The policy increases channels during low latency and decreases under contention, with symmetric recovery. Contention is injected via elevated latency values in the profiler map.**

# 6 RELATED WORK

*Collective communication optimization.* MSCCL [2] and TACCL [6] synthesize static communication schedules offline; they do not address runtime policy selection or safety. AutoCCL [1] automates tuning via search but uses native code without verification. MSCCL++ [5] provides GPU-driven communication primitives at the mechanism layer. NCCLPol operates at the policy layer and is complementary: a policy can activate synthesized schedules based on dynamic conditions.

*eBPF for systems extensibility.* XRP [9] embeds eBPF in the kernel's NVMe path, exploiting the same insight that certain system paths are latency-tolerant enough for eBPF overhead. Electrode [10] accelerates distributed protocols; eTran [3] applies eBPF to RDMA network functions; PageFlex [7] extends eBPF to page management. No prior work applies eBPF to GPU collective communication. bpftime [8] provides the userspace eBPF runtime substrate that NCCLPol builds upon.

*Alternative safe-extension mechanisms.* WebAssembly provides sandboxed execution but lacks eBPF's static termination and memory-safety verification; its runtime overhead is typically higher due to bounds checks that eBPF eliminates statically. Out-of-process services provide strong isolation but add microseconds of IPC latency—an order of magnitude more than NCCLPol's 52–100 ns in-process overhead. Declarative DSLs are safe by construction but cannot express stateful policies or feedback loops. Hardware isolation (Intel MPK) provides memory separation without verification; a policy

can still loop indefinitely. eBPF provides both verification and efficient execution in a single model with a mature toolchain.

## 7 DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSION

*Limitations and future work.* NCCLPol currently targets NCCL's tuner and profiler interfaces; the net plugin involves complex state (RDMA queue pairs, memory registrations) that does not map cleanly to eBPF's restricted model. Our evaluation uses 2 ranks on a single node; multi-node experiments with InfiniBand transport and large rank counts are important future work. The restricted C programming model is familiar to eBPF developers but presents a barrier for ML engineers; a higher-level policy DSL compiled to BPF would improve usability. Most importantly, our evaluation demonstrates that the mechanism works but does not yet show that adaptive eBPF policies improve end-to-end training outcomes. Demonstrating benefit on production workloads at scale is the key next step.

*Conclusion.* We presented NCCLPol, a system that transforms NCCL's unsafe native plugin extension points into verified, composable policy hooks by embedding a userspace eBPF runtime. The key insight is that NCCL's CPU-side decision path is latency-tolerant enough to absorb eBPF overhead. NCCLPol adds 52–100 ns per decision (under 0.06% of collective latency), catches common crash-inducing bugs at load time, and supports atomic hot-reload (∼7.3 ms total, 0.774 µs on the hot path) without call loss. The system requires zero NCCL modifications. Beyond NCCL, the pattern of embedding verified eBPF execution in latency-tolerant CPU-side decision paths may apply to other parts of the accelerator software stack.

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